

Breaking the scrum ceiling: What the RPL means for Indian rugby

Can franchise sport breathe life into Indian rugby? Inside the making of RPL — **a bold experiment** in commercialising and scaling a niche game.

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When Javed Hussain, the Hyderabad Heroes star, walked into a plush Mumbai hotel for the first time, he instinctively video-called his parents. For the next 20 minutes, words eluded him. He silently walked around, showing them every corner of the luxurious room. His parents, emotional and wide-eyed, had never experienced such opulence. As they blessed their son through the screen, Javed, too, struggled to hold back tears.

It was a long way from the informal settlements of Vasant Kunj in New Delhi, where Javed's rugby journey had begun. Back then, the idea of playing in a televised, franchise-based league — let alone sharing space with global icons — was unimaginable. But the inaugural edition of the Rugby Premier League (RPL) has turned that distant dream into a vivid reality.

The RPL has not only elevated Indian rugby's visibility but also opened new doors for players like Javed.

"We lived in *juggis* (makeshift homes), and there was a jungle behind where we used to go to relieve ourselves since we didn't have toilets," Javed told *Sportstar*. "Then, Earth Foundation, an NGO, cleared the jungle and made it into a rugby ground."

That piece of land became a turning point. Coaches from Delhi Hurricanes, in collaboration with the NGO, began training children there.

"I didn't even understand the sport at first. I was scared of the older boys. But one of the coaches told me he'd give me a 'Tiger' biscuit packet after training. For those biscuits, I got greedy and started playing," he said with a grin.

Javed grew to love the game, but the COVID-19 pandemic nearly ended his journey. Forced to stop playing, he began delivering milk in his neighbourhood to support his family.

"I thought my career was over," he recalled. But when normalcy returned, so did his dream. Eventually, Javed broke into the Indian national team.

His story isn't an outlier. Many promising players have dropped out mid-way, unable to balance passion with survival. But for the first time, the RPL offers a glimmer of hope. Despite rugby sevens enjoying global popularity, in India the sport has historically remained confined to Kolkata, Mumbai, and Odisha — each carrying its own social and economic contours.

When actor and former rugby international Rahul Bose took charge as president of Rugby India, he envisioned a future where Indian players could compete and learn

alongside international stars. For that, he knew, a well-structured, broadcast-friendly league was essential.

Mumbai emerged as the ideal launchpad: equipped with suitable venues and the logistical ease that comes with being India's financial capital.

Still, the road to RPL was anything but easy. Convincing stakeholders to invest in a sport seen as niche and commercially risky took months of effort. But perseverance paid off. GMR came on board as title sponsor, and GMR Sports partnered with Rugby India to organise the world's first franchise-based rugby sevens league. The debut edition featured six franchises and attracted some of the sport's most recognisable names.

As the Chennai Bulls clinched the inaugural title, Bose remained clear-eyed about the task ahead:

"The spillover effect of the RPL has to permeate into the larger Indian rugby ecosystem. That's our responsibility as a federation," he said.

For GMR Sports, the move into rugby wasn't a shot in the dark.

"It's not as if rugby randomly came our way," said Satyam Trivedi, CEO of GMR Sports. "We had a clear, structured framework. Rugby fits into it."

He added that while rugby in